TYPES OF LEADS



Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

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Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

WHAT IS SUMMARY LEAD?

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

SUMMARY LEAD

- The summary lead tells the most important information about a situation or event.
- It tells the results, or the climax, of the story.
- It answers the questions: Who? What? Where? When
- Usually it tries to answer: How? Why?
- The summary lead is the equivalent of a thesis in a scholarly paper, except that in news, it appears as the first sentence of the story.
- The summary lead does not include every minute detail.
- The details are saved for the body of the story.

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

SUMMARY LEAD: EXAMPLES

DOVER – A speeding car passed a minivan on a state highway and slammed into a car traveling in the other direction near this eastern Ohio town, killing four people, the Ohio Highway Patrol said Friday. (Associated Press, July 6, 2002)

Readers know – 1)what happened: a crash occurred that killed four people; 2) how: crossed the centerline; 3) where: indicated in the dateline of Dover (look up dateline in the AP Stylebook); 4) who: four people (see delayed-identification leads below); 5) who said: Ohio Highway Patrol; 6) when: Friday; 7) why: speed and bad judgment perhaps, although not yet known why the driver took the risk to pass.

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

SUMMARY LEAD: EXAMPLES

Southern Californians from the desert to the beach were unnerved but mostly unharmed Wednesday by a 5.5-magnitude earthquake that shattered windows, triggered rockslides and caused millions of dollars in damage in Pomona and surrounding communities.

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

SUMMARY LEAD: EXAMPLES

It wasn't as sweet as modern hot chocolate, but the Mayans were drinking cocoa 2,100 years before Columbus landed in the New World, or about 1,000 years earlier than previously thought, researchers say. (Associated Press, July 17, 2002)

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

SUMMARY LEAD: EXAMPLES

Identity theft has become a national crisis, with more Americans than ever losing personal information to scam artists, Congress was told Tuesday.

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

WHAT IS PARTIAL SUMMARY LEAD?

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

PARTIAL SUMMARY LEAD

- The partial summary lead, often used in feature stories and news stories emphasizing a particular angle, omits a few details.
- In some cases, inclusion of all the major points would create a crowded and/or confusing lead.
- In other cases, the writer wants to create suspense.
- The writer sets a tone by the language she chooses that gives readers another clue as to what the story is about. Is it about something serious? A murder? Is it lighthearted? Another stupid criminal does something stupid?

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

PITFALLS OF PARTIAL LEAD

- The significance of the story to the reader may be vague.
- Readers may be confused about the subject of the story.
- Not enough precise information is present to hook the reader.

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

PARTIAL SUMMARY LEAD: EXAMPLES

Oprah Winfrey is keeping Miami Valley Hospital busy.

Readers know that the famous talk show host has some connection to Dayton. What is it? Readers will have to read more. Interest level is raised because of the prominence of Oprah, the local prominence of the hospital, and the unusualness of Oprah having anything to do with Dayton.

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

PARTIAL SUMMARY LEAD: EXAMPLES

The jump from high school to college can be a tough transition for any teenager, but for students with learning disabilities, the hurdles are even higher. (Chicago Tribune, July 14, 2002)

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

WHAT ARE MULTIPLE ELEMENT & ROUNDUP LEADS?

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

MULTIPLE ELEMENT & ROUNDUP LEADS

- Multiple element and roundup leads are essentially summary leads that include a lot of information often about separate incidents or distinct aspects linked by time, location, type or cause.
- These leads summarize and set up the important information to follow. Most complex, in-depth stories about big issues have multiple elements.
- The pitfall is that the lead may become crowded or disorganized.

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

MULTIPLE ELEMENT & ROUNDUP LEADS

- The best approach is to identify what the elements have in common and create a main clause reflecting that point.
- Then group the other aspects, identify them by key words or phrases, prioritize the more important aspects and create subordinate phrases.
- Think of the lead as the table of contents for the rest of the story.
- Another approach is to prioritize the elements, deal with the most important in a summary lead, and then write a second paragraph that summarizes the other points.

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

MULTIPLE ELEMENT & ROUNDUP LEADS: EXAMPLES

State police reported at least 10 people died in Ohio traffic accidents over the weekend, including three who died in an accident Friday in Greene County. (Dayton Daily News, July 2002)

The writer grouped all the deaths over the weekend into one story, and then added a localized element.

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

MULTIPLE ELEMENT & ROUNDUP LEADS: EXAMPLES

Thousands of workers are leaving large cities that border Indiana to settle in Indianapolis, attracted by cheaper housing and shorter, less-congested commutes than in Chicago, Cincinnati and Louisville. (Associated Press, July 6, 2002)

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

Difference between a summary lead and a multiple element lead is…

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

Summary Lead and Multiple Element Lead

Summary leads are used if the whole is more important than any one part.

Multiple Element leads are used when two or more actions are of equal importance.

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

WHAT IS LOCALIZED LEAD?

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

LOCALIZED LEAD

- A localized lead is a summary or partial summary lead that emphasizes the local aspect of a national, regional or even international event or situation.
- The lead and significant part of the story's body emphasize what's important to your specific readers, that is, what's close to home.
- Proximity is an important news value.
- Localizing a story is itself a story angle. It's just one of the many ways to approach any event or situation.

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

LOCALIZED LEAD: EXAMPLES

More than 40 people, including a woman from Dayton, were killed in an air show crash Tuesday in southwest Kentucky.

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

LOCALIZED LEAD: EXAMPLES

An Oakwood attorney was killed and his wife injured in a plane crash that killed two other people near Green castle on Friday, authorities said.

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

LOCALIZED LEAD: EXAMPLES

Dayton is one of 50 locations in the United States to provide residents with a new technology in magnetic resonance imaging (MRI) systems. (Dayton Daily News, July 8, 2002)

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

WHAT IS FOLLOW UP LEAD?

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

FOLLOW UP LEAD

- The follow up lead, like that of any news story, emphasizes the latest and most important information about an earlier event or situation.
- Most stories are follow ups.
- Most leads will include some background information – in a word or phrase – so that readers can recall the prior situation.

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

FOLLOW UP LEAD: EXAMPLES

Stolen school computer equipment worth thousands of dollars was recovered from five Fairborn High School Students, police said Tuesday. (Dayton Daily News, July 3, 2002)

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

FOLLOW UP LEAD: EXAMPLES

A 6-year-old boy taken from a train station platform Monday was found unharmed about two hours later, and a suspect was facing kidnapping charges. (Dayton Daily News, July 3, 2002)

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

WHAT IS IMMEDIATE-IDENTIFICATION LEAD?

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

IMMEDIATE-IDENTIFICATION LEAD

- In immediate-identification leads, the who is identified by name.
- Identification of people in the lead usually is reserved for prominent people.
- Sometimes little-known people will be named in the lead where the emphasis actually is on what happened to this person.

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

IMMEDIATE-IDENTIFICATION LEAD: EXAMPLES

President Bush and Polish President Aleksander Kwasniewski agreed during a state visit Wednesday to continue the fight against threats to freedom and to boost military and economic cooperation between the two NATO allies. (New York Times, July 17, 2002)

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

IMMEDIATE-IDENTIFICATION LEAD: EXAMPLES

EX: Florida Gov. Jeb Bush's 24-year-old daughter Noelle was jailed Wednesday for not meeting the conditions of a court-ordered drug treatment plan. (Associated Press, July 18, 2002)

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

WHAT IS DELAYED-IDENTIFICATION LEAD?

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

DELAYED-IDENTIFICATION LEAD

- In the delayed-identification lead, the who is not named but is described in some manner, such as by title, age, residence or past notoriety.
- Identification is delayed because the person is not well-known and so has little meaning to readers.
- Another reason for the delayed identification is to put the emphasis on the what of the story, which is more important.

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

DELAYED-IDENTIFICATION LEAD: EXAMPLES

A 10-year-old Grand Ledge boy was seriously injured Saturday when he ran in front of a pickup truck on Center Street and was struck by the vehicle.

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

DELAYED-IDENTIFICATION LEAD: EXAMPLES

A Troy accountant went on trial Monday in Montgomery County Common Pleas Court for failing to repay $1.6 million to investors.

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

DELAYED-IDENTIFICATION LEAD: EXAMPLES

A fired construction worker suspected of ambushing and shooting his former boss in an Irvine parking garage surrendered at his Riverside County home Wednesday night after a three-hour standoff with police. (Associated Press, July 2002)

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

WHAT IS FEATURE LEAD?

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

FEATURE LEAD

- Basically, leads with flair are feature leads.
- They come in various formats, including the anecdote, description, staccato, zinger, flashback, direct address and representative example.
- These leads essentially, might be considered partial summaries that emphasize the novelty of the situation or person.
- They give some precise information and then suggest the story's theme, tone and genre through language, rhythm and style.

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

FEATURE LEAD: EXAMPLES

In preparation for tonight's poetry reading, Charles Bukowski is out in the parking lot, vomiting.

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FEATURE LEAD: EXAMPLES

The jury had left.
The sentence had been read.
Jerry Scott Heidler's face was still as stone.
Only when Superior Court Judge Walter C. McMillan Jr. actually sentenced Heidler to death for the murder of the Daniels family did Heidler break down for the first time and cry. (Leonora Bohen LaPeter, Savannah Morning News, Sept. 4, 1999)

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002

THANK YOU!

Source: Professor Annette Taylor, University of Dayton, 2002